

Clothes in the Space Station

Astronauts wear various types of clothing for all aspects of a mission to space. Whether preparing for launch, working inside the space shuttle or the space station, working outside in space, or landing back on Earth, astronauts wear the proper garments for both comfort and protection.

ISS crewmembers choose the shirts, shorts and pants they will wear in space months before they are scheduled to launch. In fact, their clothes often arrive at the space station before they do, via a Progress resupply vehicle or a space shuttle.

Space station crews can choose from either Russian or US clothing supplies. They also have the option of ordering two versions of Russian coveralls – heavy or light-duty – to work in.

Because it's expensive to take supplies into space and there's no washing machine aboard the space station – in order to save water – station crews don't change clothes as often as people do on Earth. Of course, since they don't go outside, except in a spacesuit, they don't get as dirty as people living on Earth.

On average, station crewmembers get one pair of shorts and a T-shirt for every three days of exercising. Their work shirts and pants/shorts are changed, on average, once every 10 days. Crewmembers generally get a new T-shirts to wear under their work shirts every 10 days. Underwear and socks are changed every other day, but Polartec socks – which are worn if a crewmember's feet get cold – must last a month. They also get two sweaters.

In addition, each crewmember gets a pair of running shoes to use on the station's treadmill and another pair of shoes to wear when using the station's exercise bicycle.

When a piece of clothing has been worn as many times as possible, it's placed in a bag for disposal. Very little clothing is brought back to Earth. Most of it is eventually placed in the Progress resupply vehicle before it undocks from the space station. The dirty clothing and other garbage then burns up with the Progress when it re-enters the Earth's atmosphere.

Clothes for launch and landing

During launch and entry aboard a space shuttle, crew members use the US-made orange Launch and Entry Suits (LES) or the Russian-made white Sokol suit. The two suits are similar in almost every aspect apart from the colour.

In the event of a pressure leak in the space shuttle's flight cabin, these suits would maintain a positive air pressure around the astronaut. This pro-